invested in maintaining ‘that Hinduism was always the pure-minded, anti-erotic, ascetic tradition’ they now subscribe to.[54] On the other hand, Hindu liberals, few as they are, feel pride in a past that produced the *Kamasutra* and Khajuraho, scratch their heads and wonder what caused this dramatic cultural shift. They usually blame it on the coming of Islam and the puritanical Protestantism of Europeans.

Doniger reminds us, ‘Blaming the Muslims and the British ignores the history of native Hindu anti-eroticism. For, as we have seen, India had its own home-grown traditions of prudery [that predate them both] in opposition to its own sensuality.’[55] In an interview, Kakar accepts that both Muslim and British rule had a role to play, ‘but the more fundamental factor in the rejection of the erotic has to be looked for within the Hindu culture itself’. He adds:

> It is the ascetic tradition in Hinduism that is the real counterforce which undermined the Kamasutra legacy. The duality of eroticism vs asceticism dialectic has been always a part of Hindu culture. The one or the other might become dominant in a particular period of history though the other is never submerged. [When] the Kamasutra was composed there were other texts holding fast to the ascetic ideal and extolling the virtues of celibacy for spiritual progress. The ascetic ideal, that can degenerate into puritanism, is then also quintessentially Indian, perennially in competition with the erotic one for possession of the Indian soul. It is very unlikely that ancient Indians were ever, or even could be, as unswerving in their pursuit of pleasure as, for instance, ancient Romans. That India has been a sexual wasteland for the last two centuries is then due to a combination of British prudery, adopted by the upper classes in what may be called an ‘identification with the aggressor’, and our own deep-seated strain of Brahminical asceticism . . .[56]

As Doniger and others have pointed out, the reconstruction of India’s past by Europeans has profoundly shaped Hindu self-knowledge. Modern Hindus began understanding their history and culture through the colonizer’s eyes, using the latter’s concepts, categories and judgements. Meanwhile, British orientalists—with their Victorian values, Christian sexual morality and Brahminical native informants—valorized the indigenous strains of sexual prudery in Hinduism, at whose heart they placed the most austere of Vedantic ideas and texts like the Bhagavad Gita and Manusmriti, demoting and devaluing so many other strands of folk spirituality and religious practices, including Tantrism.[57] They emphasized only a small part of the Indian story.